

to be in sleep mode—with no raids, no FIRS or investigation.

This does not mean that Bihar's babus have mended their ways. Traps set by the SVB are yielding results almost every month. Of the over 375 officials arrested, the SVB is said to have discovered trails of assets running in crores from 300 of them.

In 2006, the SVB arrested Madhepura's DM Hemchandra Jha with Rs 1.9 lakh cash he had allegedly taken as bribe. He was taken into custody in Patna when he was on his way from Madhepura to his residence. Jha's vehicle was intercepted by sleuths and a search was carried out which led to the recovery of the money. He is now out on bail.

from backwaters never stop reporting corruption details. He knows he has the haystack and he needs to look for the needle.

But it's a different story at the SVU. Over the years, four of the five retired CBISPs, who had joined the SVU, are no longer with the agency and no replacements have been found. The responsibility for the poor performance can be pinned on the government. A scrutiny puts a question mark over the efficacy and commitment of the anti-corruption measures and their implementation.

Top vigilance officers confirm that unlike the past there is "zero inter-

in his blog. But words alone will not push the stagnated measures to the finish line. This is one reason why the recent decision of constituting six special courts to implement the Bihar Special Court Act 2009—enacted this year following a presidential accent—has created hype, but very little hope exists. Rules have already been framed in accordance with the special laws that have enhanced the state's power to deal with corrupt officials. The law provides for the confiscation of the officer's property after the final adjudication—which is to be delivered 'within a maximum period of six months' from the time the delinquent officer is served a notice.

"Bihar has shown zero-tolerance

(CLOCKWISE FROM RIGHT) HEMCHAND JHA'S RESIDENCE; JHA; GAYA'S ASSISTANT MINING DIRECTOR, SUDHIR KUMAR, WAS TRAPPED BY SVB WHILE TAKING A BRIBE OF RS 15,000



In another case in 2009, the SVB unearthed possessions worth crores from an inspector, Om Prakash Singh, in the Weights and Measures Department. With a monthly salary of Rs 15,000, Om Prakash had almost set up a mini empire. The SVB discovered proof of the ownership of 40 plots of land in and around Patna, three palatial homes, around Rs 21 lakh in various bonds, 10-acre agricultural land, investment of Rs 14 lakh, Rs 6.5 lakh in 13 bank accounts, 30 fixed deposits worth Rs 5 lakh and a lot more.

Anil Sinha, ADG Vigilance, too keeps receiving calls and SMSs on his cell phone where enthusiastic callers

vention from the top." In that case, the failure in taking the cases to logical conclusions appears even bigger. But, is it just a case of good intention and bad delivery?

Nitish has emerged as a politician with purpose who combines in himself clarity of thought and commitment to weed out corruption, in the right proportion. It is no wonder he has very good approval ratings. But, the factsheet might just take some sheen off Nitish's shining signposts, which declare an unrelenting crackdown against corrupt government officials. "It is no longer possible for anybody to commit any crime and get away with it in Bihar," writes Nitish

on corruption. The corrupt will have to pay a very high price," said Ashok Kumar Chauhan, principal secretary, Vigilance Department. The 1980 batch IAS officer is convinced that the new law will give a decisive boost to the anti-corruption campaign.

Nitish has also declared his intent of setting up schools on confiscated properties. Such statements would surely work during elections. But, there is also a legion of doubters, who believe that special laws and courts are only half the battle. Though the vigilance crackdown is the hallmark that Nitish proudly wears on his starched-white sleeves; a reality check seems to be the need of the hour. ■